that the prime minister had talked tough and even offered his resignation to Sonia Gandhi. The breaking news story we did had several sceptics who were unconvinced the mild-mannered prime minister would dare Mrs Gandhi to remove him. The story, though, was later confirmed, and the gambit worked. Even as the left withdrew support, Sonia Gandhi and the party rallied around Dr Singh. Eventually, the Samajwadi Party bailed out his government. In the election that followed, the voter rewarded Dr Singh's clear-cut stand. UPA-II was created with a much stronger majority. And yet, in his moment of political success, Dr Singh would make his first major mistake as prime minister and reveal himself to be a political survivor who preferred compromise to conviction.

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Dr Manmohan Singh was sworn in as India's prime minister for a second time, on 22 May 2009, along with nineteen ministers. Absent from the ceremony was a key UPA ally, the Tamil Nadu-based Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK). Their absence at the swearing-in became a major talking point. M. Karunanidhi, we were told, was incensed that he was not being allowed the ministers and portfolios of his choice. The prime minister's office had leaked the story that Dr Singh was unhappy with the performance of the DMK ministers in his first government, especially T.R. Baalu's and A. Raja's, both of whom were accused of corruption. 'The DMK wants "wet" ATM ministries!' was the joke in the corridors of power.

As the prime minister revealed a muscular refusal to bend, a worried Congress party decided to send senior leader Ghulam Nabi Azad and the national security adviser M.K. Narayanan to Chennai to negotiate with the DMK supremo. Karunanidhi was equally unrelenting. 'I must have the right to choose my ministers and portfolios. Raja comes from a Dalit family, we cannot remove him.' When the negotiators tried to broach the issue of corruption allegations, the DMK leader reportedly shot back, 'Who is the Congress to talk about corruption? You people even protected Ottavio